



Ophiacodon

oh-fee-ACK-oh-don

- **When** 310–290 million years ago (Late Carboniferous–Early Permian)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Swamps
- **Length** 10 ft (3 m)
- **Diet** Fish and small animals

This large predator had a very long skull and huge jaws packed with 170 sharp, pointed teeth. It was built like a crocodile and may

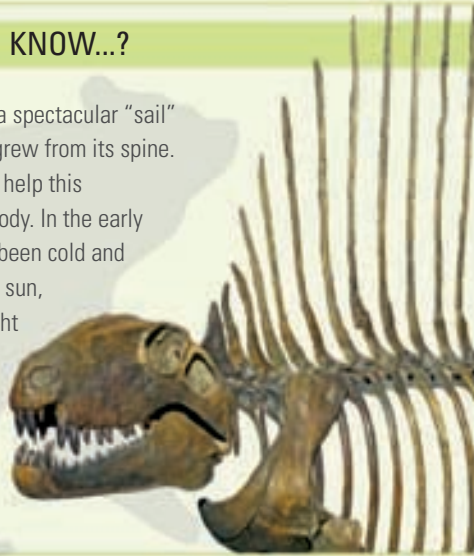
even have hunted like a crocodile, lurking in swamps or rivers ready to ambush passing prey. However, *Ophiacodon* is unlikely to have been an underwater hunter, since its tall skull would have been difficult to swing sideways in water, making prey such as fish difficult to catch. On land, *Ophiacodon* walked with its limbs sprawled like a lizard, dragging its tail behind it.



DID YOU KNOW...?

Running along *Dimetrodon's* back was a spectacular “sail” supported by tall rods of bone that grew from its spine.

The sail might have been used to help this cold-blooded creature warm its body. In the early morning, *Dimetrodon* would have been cold and sluggish. Perhaps it basked in the sun, turning its body so the sail caught the sun's rays. Blood flowing through the sail would have spread the warmth through the rest of the body, helping *Dimetrodon* become active.



Sail

Varanops

VA-ran-ops

- **When** 260 million years ago (Late Permian)
- **Fossil location** USA, Russia
- **Habitat** Swamps
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Small animals



Varanops looked like a modern monitor lizard. Compared to other pelycosaurs it was a fast-moving hunter with long legs, well suited to scampering after small animals, which it caught and killed with strong jaws lined with dozens of backward-curved teeth. *Varanops* lived in the Late Permian and was one of the last of the pelycosaurs.

Eothyris

ee-oh-THY-riss

- **When** 280 million years ago (Early Permian)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Swamps
- **Length** Skull 2½ in (6 cm)
- **Diet** Meat



Only a single fossil of *Eothyris* exists: a broad, flat skull that was discovered in 1937. It shows that *Eothyris* probably had a quick, snapping bite. On each side of the upper jaw were two large fangs. The remaining teeth were smaller but sharply pointed, so *Eothyris* was a flesh-eater. A small animal, it perhaps hunted insects or reptiles smaller than itself.

